Advanced Proposal Writing Techniques

- Leveraging data-driven strategies to enhance proposal success
- Based on the Shipley webinar “Advanced Proposal Writing Strategies,” with Nia Mahali (Shipley) and Kevin Plexico (Deltech / GovWin)
- Goal: move your score from “outstanding” to “far exceeds”
- Presenter: [add your name] Audience: [add your audience]

SPEAKER NOTES

Welcome, everyone. Today’s session is based on a Shipley webinar on advanced proposal writing strategies, with guest insight from Deltech’s GovWin team. The core idea is simple: to win, a proposal has to go from merely good, or even outstanding, to far exceeding what the client expects, and data is how you get there. We will move through the agenda, the role of market intelligence, building features and benefits from data, and then a summary of the Q&A, key takeaways and a glossary. Presenter’s suggestion (not from the video): fill in your name and audience on this slide before presenting.

Agenda

- **1.** Introductions to the speakers
- **2.** Overview of data-driven proposal writing
- **3.** The importance of market intelligence for proposal writing
- **4.** Developing discriminators, features and benefits
- **5.** Client requirements analysis and competitor analysis
- **6.** Integrating all of that data into proposals, then Q&A

SPEAKER NOTES

Here is the roadmap. We start with the speakers, then Nia gives an overview of data-driven proposal writing. Kevin explains why market intelligence matters and how to use it, after which we return to developing discriminators, features and benefits. We then cover client requirements analysis and competitor analysis, and finish by integrating all of that data into the proposal itself. The original session closed with a live Q&A, which this deck summarizes in Section E.

About the Webinar and the Speakers

- **Shipley:** began as a training company 50+ years ago; expanded into consulting and process improvement; still trains corporate teams and individuals who want to win more contracts
- **Mallerie Price:** moderator
- **Nia Mahali:** Senior Vice President of Professional Services, Shipley; webinar facilitator
- **Kevin Plexico:** Senior Vice President of Information Solutions, Deltech; manages the GovWin market intelligence platform and research team
- Planned length: about 45 minutes; counted toward continuing education units for APMP certification

SPEAKER NOTES

A quick word on who is speaking. Shipley started as a training company more than 50 years ago and grew into consulting and process improvement, and it still offers training to corporations and to individuals who want to win more contracts. Mallerie Price moderated the session. Nia Mahali, a senior vice president of professional services at Shipley, facilitated. Kevin Plexico is a senior vice president of information solutions at Deltech and manages the GovWin market intelligence platform and its research team. The session was designed to last about 45 minutes, and it applied toward continuing education units for APMP members.

Section A: Data-Driven Proposal Writing

IN THIS SECTION

- What “advanced proposal writing” really means
- Why an “outstanding” score can still lose
- What the data says about winning proposals
- What to do when the RFP drops and no capture was done

SPEAKER NOTES

This first section sets up the problem and the philosophy. We will see what advanced proposal writing is, why an outstanding score can still lose, what ‘data-driven’ really means, and what to do when an RFP lands with little or no capture behind it. Everything later in the session builds on these ideas.

What Is Advanced Proposal Writing?

- Webinar focus: leveraging data-driven strategies to enhance proposal success
- “Data-driven” means systematic processes, not guesswork
- Advanced proposal writing = specific techniques to move your score beyond “good” and from “outstanding” to “far exceeds”
- In practice: apply systematic processes in proposals and give highly data-driven responses
- The goal: maximize your points so you win

SPEAKER NOTES

The webinar’s focus is leveraging data-driven strategies to enhance proposal success, which in practice means systematic processes. Advanced proposal writing is not about prettier prose. It is a set of specific techniques for pushing your evaluation score beyond ‘good’ and, most importantly, from ‘outstanding’ to ‘far exceeds.’ You do that by applying systematic processes in the proposal and giving highly data-driven responses. The aim is simple: maximize the points you earn so that you win.

The Problem: Outstanding Can Still Lose

- Common scenario: you make the down-select and reach the top three
- The debrief shows an “outstanding” on the technical volume, and you still lose
- “Outstanding” and “far exceeds” are different; the nuance decides the win
- In government contracting: moving the score from green to blue
- Far exceeds = you far exceed both the client’s expectations and the competition

SPEAKER NOTES

Many organizations recognize this scenario. They make the down-select, they are in the top three, they are excited, and then the debrief shows an ‘outstanding’ in the technical volume, and they still lost. The reason is a nuance: outstanding is not far exceeds. In government contracting that is the move from a green score to a blue score. You can be outstanding and lose, but far exceeding the client’s expectations and the competition is where you win.

Where This Applies and Why Scoring Is So Formal

- Primarily competitive, best-value procurements
- All stakeholders have formal, delineated scoring processes: documented, evaluated and kept on file
- Applies in any industry: business-to-government and business-to-business
- Why: in GovCon, protests; in business-to-business, buyers don’t want to be sued
- Advanced techniques address the scoring directly so you can maximize points

SPEAKER NOTES

These techniques matter most in competitive, best-value procurements. Every stakeholder in that situation has a formal, delineated scoring process that is documented, evaluated and kept on file. That is true whether you sell business-to-government or business-to-business. In GovCon the driver is protests, and in business-to-business, buyers simply do not want to get sued. Because scoring is so structured, advanced proposal writing aims directly at the scoring so that you can maximize your points.

The “Science”: What the Data Shows

- The science = what data has been collected, analyzed and presented
- In government contracting, this essentially means capture
- Shipley: 54 years analyzing thousands of proposals; a dedicated data analyst whose only job is finding patterns in winning and losing
- Finding: proposals packed with condensed data have the highest chance of winning, seen continuously for 50+ years
- GovWin is a remarkable source of data for this work

SPEAKER NOTES

The ‘science’ is the data that has been collected, analyzed and presented. In government contracting, that is essentially capture. Shipley has spent 54 years analyzing thousands of proposals, and it employs a data analyst whose only job is to identify patterns in winning and losing. The consistent finding over more than 50 years is that proposals with condensed, data-packed content have the highest chance of winning. That is also why Deltech’s GovWin, a remarkable source of data, is part of this conversation.

When the RFP Drops and No Capture Was Done

- Reality: you are sometimes told to bid because “the client loves us,” with no capture behind it
- You still have to pursue it, so the question is how to position yourself to win
- Shipley’s Four C’s: the client, the customer, the company, and cost last on best value [unclear in transcript: the second “C” may be “competition”]
- Cost is always a main criterion, so keep it competitive; research how much money the client has and what competitors may bid
- Focusing on the client and customer will not mislead you

SPEAKER NOTES

We have all been in this spot: you are directed to bid, with the explanation that the client loves us, and no capture was done. You still have to pursue it, so how do you position to win? Shipley recommends its Four C’s, with the client and the other external factors first and cost last on a best-value award. Cost is still always a main criterion in government contracting, so it must stay competitive, and part of your research is how much money the client has and what the competition may bid. This is where GovWin comes in. Note for accuracy: the transcript is unclear on the exact wording of the Four C’s, so confirm the second ‘C’ against Shipley’s material before presenting.

Spend 20% of Your Time on Capture First

- Shipley recommends spending about 20% of your time running capture before writing anything
- True whether you ran capture for three years or not at all
- Go back to the drawing board: what are the client’s needs?
- How is the competition positioned, and who are they?
- Then ask: how can I far exceed on both of those criteria?

SPEAKER NOTES

Whether you have run capture for three years or not at all, Shipley recommends spending about 20 percent of your time on capture before you write anything. Go back to the drawing board and ask what the client’s needs are, how the competition is positioned, and who the competitors are. Then ask how you can far exceed on both of those criteria. Presenter’s suggestion (not from the video): use this as a rule of thumb to show your team when schedule pressure tempts everyone to start writing immediately.

From “We Do It” to “We Own It”

- Outstanding = “we do the stuff”; that alone won’t win, depending on who bids and what the client wants
- To own it, you must know what the client wants beyond their website and what competitors are doing
- That is where the data, and advanced proposal writing, come in
- Model claim: “We are better because we increased this by X%, we did it on 72 contracts, we plan to apply it here, and here’s how”

SPEAKER NOTES

Think of outstanding as ‘we do the stuff.’ Doing the stuff alone will not win, because it depends on who is bidding and what the client wants. To own the stuff, you must know what the client wants beyond what is on its website and what the competition is doing. That knowledge is where the data comes in, and it is the heart of advanced proposal writing. The model claim is specific: we are better because we increased this by X percent, we did it on 72 contracts, we plan to apply it here, and here is how. Kevin now explains how to find the client and competitor data.

Section B: Market Intelligence for Proposal Teams

IN THIS SECTION

- Presented by Kevin Plexico, Deltech (GovWin)
- Why proposal teams need their own market intelligence
- Trends to watch: spending, pricing, cybersecurity, small business, executive orders
- Using public procurement data to profile competitors and agencies

SPEAKER NOTES

Kevin Plexico now takes over to show how market intelligence supports proposal writing, using GovWin as the example platform. He keeps the GovWin pitch short and focuses on what proposal teams can do with public data: understand the market, verify competitors and teammates, and weave agency insight into the proposal.

GovWin in Brief

- A research team plus data-aggregation tools
- Brings the government’s transparency information into a single platform
- Helps you find opportunities, build your pipeline, and get intelligence on the agency and the competitive environment
- Served up so it is easy to consume, versus piecing together public sources
- Kevin’s note: this is not an infomercial; many customers already know GovWin

SPEAKER NOTES

Kevin stressed that this is not an infomercial. GovWin combines a research team with data-aggregation tools that bring the government’s transparency information into one platform. You use it to find opportunities, build a pipeline and get the intelligence you need on the agency and the competitive environment. His claim is that it serves that information up in a way that is easy to consume compared with relying on public sources one by one. Many of Shipley’s customers already use it.

Why Proposal Teams Need Their Own Market Intelligence

- Proposal shops often see customer intimacy as the business development (BD) team’s job
- Rely on BD for inside information and relationships, but keep your own tools to stay current on the opportunity
- Example: an amendment drops; you need to know right away, not when BD tells you tomorrow
- Track the agency’s strategic plan and the companies you are bidding against
- Goal: immerse yourself in the agency’s mindset and how it will evaluate bids

SPEAKER NOTES

Kevin often hears from proposal shops that customer intimacy and customer knowledge belong to the business development team. He agrees you should rely on BD for inside information and relationships, but you also need your own resources to stay current. If an amendment drops, you cannot wait for the BD person to tell you tomorrow, because it affects your weekend and your week. Proposal managers should also track the agency’s strategic plan and the companies they are bidding against, and immerse themselves in how the agency will evaluate bids.

Top Trend: Budgets, Spending and Agency Workforce

- Source: a report produced at the start of the year on top trends for contractors; the new administration touches every trend
- Budget and spending have been very uneven across agencies
- Reductions in force vary: DoD has talked about layoffs but not moved; GSA and the Office of Personnel Management have already acted
- Confirm your contacts are still in place; people may have turned over
- This is real-time information you need while writing

SPEAKER NOTES

Kevin drew on a report produced at the start of the year on top trends for contractors, and noted that the new administration touches every one of them. Budget and spending have been very uneven across agencies. DoD has talked about laying people off but has not moved forward, while GSA and the Office of Personnel Management have already taken action. Because it varies by agency, make sure your contacts are still there, since people may have turned over. This is real-time information you need while writing. Presenter’s suggestion (not from the video): these conditions were described as current at the time of recording, so verify them before presenting.

Top Trend: Pricing and Economic Conditions

- Economic conditions are having a big impact on pricing
- Tariffs can affect your supply chain if products are part of your proposal
- On fixed-price contracts, understand the risk you take on if tariffs change your costs
- Revisit labor costs, product costs and suppliers in light of the dynamic environment

SPEAKER NOTES

Economic conditions are affecting pricing. If products are part of your proposal, tariffs can disrupt your supply chain. On a fixed-price contract, think carefully about the risk you take on if tariffs change your costs. Kevin’s advice is to revisit your pricing strategy: your labor costs, your product costs and your suppliers, and how the dynamic environment may affect each of them.

Top Trend: Cybersecurity and CMMC

- Cybersecurity compliance is front of mind; defense contractors handling controlled unclassified data are asked to sign on to CMMC and get certified
- Common question: with talk of deregulation, will CMMC go away?
- Kevin’s view: unlikely, because CMMC was born under the prior Trump administration
- Katie Arrington, described as CMMC’s brainchild, has been rehired as the DoD’s CIO
- Conclusion: cybersecurity is probably not where deregulation will happen

SPEAKER NOTES

Cybersecurity compliance is front of mind, particularly for defense contractors who touch controlled unclassified data and are being asked to sign on to CMMC and obtain certification. Many people asked whether deregulation will end CMMC. Kevin’s answer is probably not: CMMC was born under the prior Trump administration, and Katie Arrington, described as its brainchild, has been rehired as the CIO for the Department of Defense. So cybersecurity is probably not the area where deregulation will take place.

Top Trend: Small Business, Teaming and Acquisition Policy

- Small business, teaming and joint-venture rules are complex
- Many small and large businesses use joint ventures and mentor-protégé JV programs to strengthen past performance and bid; teaming strategy matters more than ever
- New SBA administrator (hired within the prior two weeks): day-one goal is to streamline small business regulations
- No leader yet named for the Office of Federal Procurement Policy; acquisition and IT policy still being formed
- Build compliance capabilities long before the RFP; they may be needed in place at submission

SPEAKER NOTES

Small business regulation is complex, and so are teaming relationships and joint-venture rules. Many small and large businesses use mentor-protégé joint ventures to strengthen past performance and bid, so your teaming strategy matters more than ever. The newly hired SBA administrator said the day-one strategy was to look at ways to streamline small business regulations. A leader for the Office of Federal Procurement Policy had not yet been named, so acquisition and IT policy were still being formulated. The lesson: do not wait until an RFP drops to learn the compliance requirements. Build those capabilities long before, because you may need them in place at submission, and you cannot always control that clock.

Real-Time Signals: Recent Executive Orders

- Agencies challenged to formulate reduction-in-force plans; also to review their real estate footprint and consider relocating staff or functions outside the DC area
- Contracting paused in many cases, with about 30 days to re-evaluate spending priorities
- Agencies to report spending and publicly justify each spend action; useful for understanding why they invest
- GSA administrator memo targeting the top 10 consulting firms (such as Accenture, Booz Allen, Deloitte); Kevin expects more essential than non-essential work

SPEAKER NOTES

Kevin summarized recent executive orders from the previous two weeks. Agencies were challenged to formulate reduction-in-force plans, review their real estate and space needs, and consider relocating staff or functions outside the DC area. Many agencies were asked to pause contracting, with about 30 days to re-evaluate spending, and to report their spending with a public justification for each action. That public justification gives market-intelligence firms, and you, insight into why agencies buy what they buy. A GSA memo also targeted the top 10 consulting firms, such as Accenture, Booz Allen and Deloitte, though Kevin expects the review will find more essential than non-essential work.

The Transparency Advantage: Public Data Systems

- Because the government must be transparent, contractors can leverage that public information in bids and proposals
- **Integrated Acquisition Environment:** statutory programs, mostly run by GSA, with data available to customers and contractors
- **FPDS:** system of record for contract activity; USAspending represents this data
- **SAM.gov:** procurement opportunities; companies and their subcontractors must register and get a unique entity identifier (replacing the old DUNS number)

SPEAKER NOTES

Because the government must be transparent, contractors can use public data to their advantage in bids and proposals. The Integrated Acquisition Environment is a statutory set of programs, mostly run by GSA, that provides tools for acquisition professionals, and the resulting data is available to customers and contractors. FPDS, the Federal Procurement Data System, is the system of record for contract activity; USAspending is essentially a representation of that data, as seen in screenshots from the DOGE receipts page. SAM.gov carries procurement opportunities, and agencies now require companies and their subcontractors to register there and obtain a unique entity identifier, the replacement for the old DUNS number.

Competitive Intelligence: Verify Companies in SAM

- Firmographic data: location, headquarters, affiliated organizations, socioeconomic status
- Companies certify annually, including size criteria and primary NAICS codes
- Verify a subcontractor’s claims in SAM instead of taking their word for it
- Agencies will check the same records, so make sure yours and your subs’ SAM registrations are current and accurate
- Check that no one on your team is excluded, suspended or debarred

SPEAKER NOTES

Public records reveal firmographic details: where a company is located and headquartered, which organizations it is affiliated with, and its socioeconomic status. Companies must certify annually, including their size and primary NAICS codes, so you can verify a subcontractor’s claims in SAM instead of taking their word for it. Agencies will check the same records, so make sure your SAM registration, and your subcontractors’, is current and accurate. Also confirm that nobody on your team is excluded or suspended, because the government cannot do business with debarred or suspended companies, and you do not want one to appear on your team unintentionally.

Competitive Intelligence: Compare Past Performance

- Use FPDS to compare your past performance with competitors’; search their contracts by keywords and NAICS codes
- See how deep their history runs relative to yours, and spot gaps
- May reveal your own past performance you didn’t know about; many companies lack a shared internal system of record
- Subcontracting reports show where small businesses hold subcontracts, a proxy for federal past performance

SPEAKER NOTES

FPDS lets you compare your past performance with your competitors’. If you are bidding on a case management system or a tech support procurement and expect four or five competitors, you can search their contracts by keyword and NAICS code to see how deep their history runs relative to yours. It can expose gaps, and it can even reveal past performance you did not know you had, since many companies lack a shared internal system of record and end up scrambling across account teams asking whether anyone did this before. For small businesses without a prime history, subcontracting reports show where they hold subcontracts, which acts as a proxy for federal past performance.

Applying It: Weave Agency Strategy into the Proposal

- Depend on BD for strategy, the capture plan and win themes
- Go a layer deeper: in a 50-100 page proposal, weave in the agency’s strategy and tie each win theme to it
- Agencies sometimes publish specific data points (such as case volume) you can use
- Shows the agency you know more than what a BD person collected

SPEAKER NOTES

Yes, you depend on business development for strategy, the capture plan and the win themes. But in a proposal that may run 50 or 100 pages, go a layer deeper. Weave in the agency’s own strategy and show how each win theme ties to it. Agencies sometimes publish specifics, such as case volume or other data points, that you can weave in to show you know more than a BD person collected. That signals real awareness of what the agency is working on.

Applying It: Competitor and Agency or Market Analysis

- Model your past performance against what public data shows about competitors' (it won't show how well they performed)
- On a recompete, a different winner or an option not exercised or contract not renewed may hint at weaknesses (sometimes for innocuous reasons)
- Policy shifts matter: EPA, GSA and State Department strategies have changed sharply; foreign aid dollars are being reprioritized
- Weed out prior-administration messaging; weave in current priorities only where it makes sense

SPEAKER NOTES

Model your past performance against what public data shows about competitors. It will not tell you whether they performed well, but on a recompete it can hint at weakness: if another company won and the agency later did not exercise options or renew, the customer may have been unhappy, though sometimes the reasons are innocuous. Policy shifts matter too. The EPA's strategy today is very different from before, and the same is true at GSA and the State Department, where foreign aid dollars are disappearing and being reprioritized. Weed out messaging from the prior administration, and weave in current priorities only where it makes sense. Do not force it.

Applying It: Real-Time Alerts and Closing Message

- GovWin tracks thousands of opportunities, with a real-time sync with SAM
- SAM notifications typically arrive the next morning; GovWin alerts come about 15 minutes after an amendment is released
- Why it matters: an amendment can delay an RFP or significantly change the work
- Use market data to guide collaborators, strengthen the bid and show the agency you know what it faces

SPEAKER NOTES

GovWin tracks thousands of opportunities and syncs with SAM in real time. SAM notifications typically arrive the next morning, whereas GovWin can alert you about 15 minutes after an amendment is released. That speed matters when an amendment delays an RFP or significantly changes the work. Kevin’s closing point for proposal managers is to use market data to guide collaborators, strengthen the bid and show the agency you are aware of what it deals with. Nia added that Shipley runs about 22 trainings a month, GovWin comes up in nearly every course, and Shipley has no affiliation, contractual or legal connection with it; her endorsement is genuine.

Section C: Discriminators, Features & Benefits

IN THIS SECTION

- Turning client and competitor research into proposal content
- Designing the benefit first
- Developing strong discriminators and win strategies
- Worked example: staffing and retention

SPEAKER NOTES

Now we turn the research into content. Nia explains when and how to build discriminators, features and benefits, with two concrete examples so you can see data turning into points.

When to Develop Discriminators, Features and Benefits

- Ideally in capture, even years ahead; more time raises your P-win
- When the RFP drops, have a notional pink team: management volume, technical volume, an idea of price, key personnel and past performance (even if informal)
- If not, build discriminators, features and benefits now
- Do the research; don’t copy and paste content that may speak to a previous administration
- Run capture alongside writing if you must, so content fits this market, time, opportunity and client

SPEAKER NOTES

Ideally you start this in capture, even years ahead. Shipley has always urged getting out in front of an opportunity, and more time raises your P-win. When the RFP drops you should have a notional pink team: even if it is not a formal document, something that looks like a management volume, a technical volume, an idea of price, and what key personnel and past performance will be. If you do not have that, you must build your discriminators, features and benefits now. Do the research instead of copying and pasting old text that may speak to a previous administration, and run capture alongside writing if you have to, so the content is relevant to this market, this time, this opportunity and this client.

Design the Benefit First, Then the Feature

- Industry-standard Shipley approach, seen in most proposals: create (design) the benefit first, then the feature; you don’t write it in that order
- Weak: “We have an umbrella, therefore it will protect you from the rain”
- Stronger: start from the client’s need and the competition’s solution, then show the feature that delivers the benefit
- Directly tie the benefit to the client need and the competitor solution; that is where the feature is strongest
- Answer the reviewer’s question: “So what?”

SPEAKER NOTES

This is an industry-standard Shipley approach, and you see it in most proposals. Create, meaning design, your benefit first, then your feature. You do not necessarily write it in that order. The weak version says ‘we have an umbrella, therefore it will protect you from the rain.’ The stronger version starts from the client’s need and the competition’s solution. When you tie the benefit directly to both, the feature is at its strongest. Evaluators reading a feature-only claim are silently asking, ‘so what?’

Example: Benefit First on an Army Logistics Contract

- Situation: logistics support services for the Army; the incumbent's trucks are getting flat tires because there are no awnings
- Proposal states: "At no additional cost to the government we will create awnings," with a drawing of the motor pool and current vehicles
- Benefit: no continued PMCs, and a higher readiness rate: deploy 95% of vehicles within the allocated time instead of doing maintenance
- Also address how the incumbent handles it, or, for a new opportunity, the likely competitor solution, and how yours mitigates it
- Common mistake: "We have an awning and it will help your vehicles"

SPEAKER NOTES

Nia uses a simple example from a logistics support services contract for the Army, drawing on her own Army logistics and engineering background. The incumbent's trucks keep getting flat tires because there are no awnings. The proposal says that at no additional cost to the government the company will build awnings, shows a drawing of the motor pool and the current vehicles, and states the benefit: no continued PMCs and an improved readiness rate, deploying 95 percent of vehicles within the allocated time instead of doing maintenance. Also consider how the incumbent approaches the problem, or, if it is a new opportunity, what the competition's solution likely is, and how yours mitigates it. Many contractors only write 'we have an awning, and it helps.' Presenter's suggestion (not from the video): PMCs are commonly preventive maintenance checks; explain this if your audience is non-military.

Strong Discriminators and Win Strategies

- Can’t be done in a silo; you need to know what matters to the client and what the competition has lined up
- Best fit: best-value, single-award opportunities, where you position for the best chance to win
- Large-vehicle IDIQ with thousands of competitors (not best-value direct award): compliance is key, but discriminators can still be woven into narrative sections
- Features and benefits derived from data analysis are very hard to beat

SPEAKER NOTES

You cannot develop discriminators and win strategies in a silo. You need to know what is important to the client and what the competition has lined up. This is primarily for best-value, single-award opportunities, where you are trying to position yourself to win. A large-vehicle IDIQ with thousands of competitors is not best-value direct award, so you are not worried about discriminating there; compliance still matters, but you can still weave discriminators into the narrative sections, and it does not hurt. The point: features and benefits derived from data analysis are very hard to beat.

Data Example: Setting Up the Staffing and Retention Story

- Assume research shows the competition or incumbent has a retention and staffing problem: high turnover, positions not filled on time
- For the government, risk is everything: management plan, transition plan, badge-flipping plan (classified work), staffing plan, bench of candidates
- Everyone includes these; they are part of the management volume requirements
- To reach “far exceeds,” you must know what the client wants and what the competition is doing

SPEAKER NOTES

Here is a second example. Suppose your research shows the incumbent or competition has a retention and staffing problem, with high turnover and positions not filled on time. In government contracting, risk is everything, which is why the management volume requires a management plan, a transition plan, a badge-flipping plan for classified work, a staffing plan and a bench of candidates. Everybody will include those. To move your management volume from outstanding to far exceeds, you have to know what the client wants and what the competition is doing.

Data Example: Adjectives vs. Data

- **Typical (earns few points):** “We have a robust staffing plan with a bench of qualified candidates and will backfill expeditiously”; every proposal says this, and with no data evaluators cannot score it
- **Data-driven (earns points):**
  - Retention of 93.9% on similar contracts X, Y and Z over the past 3 years, shown in a table
  - Only two people lost, because the client downsized those positions
  - X recruiters, and 362 people in the pipeline with exclusive letters of commitment
  - Backfill in 7 days or less (most contractors take two weeks) on every contract and position for 3 years, plus “here’s how we did it”

SPEAKER NOTES

The common version reads: ‘we have a robust staffing plan with a bench of qualified candidates and will backfill expeditiously.’ It earns few points because every proposal says it. It is adjectives with no data, so evaluators cannot score it. The data-driven version says retention on similar contracts X, Y and Z over three years was 93.9 percent and shows a table. It notes you lost only two people because the client downsized the positions, cites your recruiters and the 362 people in the pipeline with exclusive letters of commitment, and states you backfill within seven days or less when most contractors take two weeks, on every contract and position for three years. Then you explain how you did it. Now you are getting points, and without the data you cannot.

Section D: Client & Competitor Analysis, Putting It Together

IN THIS SECTION

- Client requirements analysis
- Competitor analysis
- Integrating research and data into the proposal
- Where to find more resources

SPEAKER NOTES

The final content section wraps up the method: analyze the client, analyze the competition, and integrate the research and data into the proposal so that it reads client-first. Nia calls these the conclusion slides, bringing together what she and Kevin covered.

Client Requirements Analysis

- Understand the client beyond the RFP
- Analyze and structure the client’s needs, and write to those needs
- Use GovWin, and similar tools, to learn about your client

SPEAKER NOTES

Nia summarized the method in a few conclusion slides. Start with client requirements analysis: understand the client beyond the RFP, analyze and structure their needs, and write to those needs. Use GovWin, or similar tools, to learn about your client.

Competitor Analysis and Content-Driven Differentiators

- Find out the competition’s strengths and weaknesses, but don’t name them
- Example phrasing: “While we understand that in the industry, because this is a prototyping and R&D effort, schedules have sometimes been missed, we plan to be ahead of schedule as we were on our past three contracts of similar size, scope and complexity, by doing this…”; then state the solution
- Without competitor analysis you can’t write this
- Develop content-driven differentiators; use GovWin to see what competitors are doing and get a head start

SPEAKER NOTES

Find out the competition’s strengths and weaknesses, but do not name them. The example phrasing is: ‘While we understand that in the industry, because this is a prototyping and R&D effort, schedules have sometimes been missed, we plan to be ahead of schedule as we were on our past three contracts of similar size, scope and complexity, by doing this,’ and then you state the solution. You cannot write that without a competitor analysis. Build content-driven differentiators, and use GovWin to see what competitors are doing; at the very least you get a head start.

Integrate Research and Data into Every Proposal

- Advanced proposal writing is not about writing beautifully “in 24-karat gold”; AI can do that now
- Shipley has an AI P-win tool (topic of its next webinar); GovWin has AI tools as well
- Strong writing makes a proposal solid, but without data it makes no difference
- Shift your focus: strength means data, research and intelligence gathering

SPEAKER NOTES

The final message is to integrate as much research and data into your proposals as possible. Advanced proposal writing is not about writing beautifully, in 24-karat gold, because AI can do that now. Shipley has an AI P-win tool, which is the topic of its next webinar, and GovWin has AI tools as well. Those tools will make a proposal solid from a writing perspective. But Nia’s long-standing line to participants is that if you write it in 24-karat gold and have no data, it makes no difference. So shift the focus of your proposals: strength means data, research and intelligence gathering.

Make It Client-Centric: How to Open Your Proposal

- Don’t start with “company superhero”: “We’re the best because we do X, Y and Z”
- Instead: the client wants this
- This is where they are right now, and where they’d like to get
- This is how we will get them there
- This is how far they got with the competition or current solutions
- And this is why ours is better

SPEAKER NOTES

Rather than starting with ‘company superhero’ language, such as ‘we are the best because we do X, Y and Z,’ start with the client. The client wants this. This is where they are right now, and this is where they would like to get. This is how we will get them there. This is how far they got with the competition or the current solutions. And this is why ours is better. That is the nutshell of a client-centric, data-driven proposal.

More Resources

- Shipley Proposal Writer book, capture manager materials and playbooks are on the Shipley website
- Attendees can email Nia for information; the address was shown on the webinar slide (not in the transcript)
- There is no charge for asking a question; Shipley can guide you to the right resources

SPEAKER NOTES

For more depth, Shipley offers its Proposal Writer book, the capture manager materials and playbooks, all on its website. Nia invited attendees to email her for more information. The address was shown on the webinar slide, not read aloud. There is no charge for asking a question, and she can guide you to the right resources. Presenter’s suggestion (not from the video): add current contact details and links to this slide before you present.

Section E: Q&A Session

IN THIS SECTION

- Q1: What trends from the new administration affect procurement and proposals?
- Q2: What if the RFP drops and there was no time for capture?
- Q3: What does “compelling” mean from an objective perspective?
- Q4: What are the most common pitfalls, and how do we avoid them?

SPEAKER NOTES

The session closed with audience questions. The next slides summarize the four questions that were answered, with each speaker’s response. Mallerie moderated and noted that unanswered questions are still read, and that frequent topics become future webinars.

Q1: Administration Trends That Affect Procurement

- **Question:** What trends or insights on the new administration affect procurement, and what changes should proposals include?
- **Kevin:** expect the acquisition environment to change quite a bit, with GSA taking on a very different role
- Speculation: GSA may take over acquisition management for some smaller agencies, given reductions in force; GSA may “lean in” to help
- Pay close attention to who will actually review your proposals
- Track turnover and staffing in the agency functions your proposal touches; keep that information real-time so your proposal fits the agency’s current environment

SPEAKER NOTES

Kevin answered first. He expects the acquisition environment to change quite a bit, with GSA taking on a very different role. There has been speculation that GSA could take over acquisition management for certain smaller agencies, especially given reductions in force, so GSA may lean in to help agencies. That makes it essential to know who will actually be reviewing the proposals you submit. He also advised tracking turnover and staffing in the agency functions your proposal touches, and keeping that information real-time so your proposal speaks correctly to the agency’s current environment. Nia had nothing to add.

Q2: Short on Time After the RFP Drops

- **Question:** No time for capture; what steps give the highest P-win?
- **Nia:** the client comes first: where are they, where do they want to be, how far have they come, and how does your solution help more than the competition's? (General change-management practice)
- Talk with teammates and industry people who have been on the contract: what is the client trying to accomplish, do they have money, what makes them look good?
- Don't copy the client's mission statement from their website; they recognize it and the scorer is turned off
- Then analyze the competition; don't skip those two steps or just write "our team is great"

SPEAKER NOTES

Nia reiterated that the client comes first. This is general change-management practice, not something Shipley invented: where is the client, where do they want to be, how far have they come, and how can our solution help more than the competition's. Get to know them by talking with teammates and with industry people who have been on the contract: what is the client trying to accomplish, do they have money, and what makes them look good? Do not copy and paste the mission statement from their website. The client wrote it, recognizes it, and the scorer is turned off. Then analyze the competition. Do not skip those two steps, even when time is short, because larger and more sophisticated opportunities draw more sophisticated competition.

Q3: What Makes a Proposal “Compelling”? (Nia)

- **Compliant** means meeting the minimum requirements, measured quantitatively
- Past performance (in business-to-business, “relevant experience”) is risk mitigation: done 71 times, likely done well the 72nd time, if similar in size, scope and complexity
- Example: a $50M opportunity with ~30 FTEs and 14 tasks; showing $45M, 17 FTEs and 7 tasks barely makes compliance
- Far exceeds requires above $50M, above 30 FTEs and above 14 tasks; not always achievable, which is why you team and use teammates’ past performance
- **Compelling** = quantifiably far exceeding the client’s needs and competitors’ solutions

SPEAKER NOTES

Nia took this question first. Compliant, she said, means meeting the minimum requirements from a quantitative perspective. Past performance, or relevant experience in business-to-business, is risk mitigation: if you have done something 71 times, you will probably do it well the 72nd time, if it is similar in size, scope and complexity. Take a $50 million opportunity with about 30 full-time employees and 14 tasks. Presenting $45 million, 17 people and seven tasks barely makes compliance. To far exceed, you need to be above $50 million, above 30 people and above 14 tasks. That is not always achievable, and that is why we team and use our teammates’ past performance, not to show we cannot manage a contract but to position ourselves as well as we can. Compelling means quantifiably far exceeding the client’s needs and the competitor’s solution.

Q3 (continued): Kevin on Bidding Blind and “Word Salad”

- Common belief: if you didn’t know about an opportunity before the RFP, don’t bid; not great to bid blind, but you may be breaking into a new agency
- Discount your P-win, but weave in market data and insights to shore up your capabilities and show you know the customer
- A federal CIO’s view: agencies are “not that smart” (or risky) to have pre-decided; they want legitimate bids
- Be honest about your capabilities versus likely competitors; strong past performance can put you in a good position
- Be specific and data-based; avoid “word salad” from novice writers

SPEAKER NOTES

Kevin added a point on this question. Companies often say that if an opportunity comes out and they did not know about it, they have no business bidding. It is not a great idea to bid on something you know nothing about, but when you are breaking into a new agency you will meet that situation. Discount your P-win, but you can still weave market data and insights into the proposal to shore up your capabilities and show the customer you know them. He recalled a federal CIO saying agencies are not that smart, or that risky, as to have decided the award already; they are looking for legitimate bids. Be honest about your capabilities against likely competitors. On compelling writing, be specific about what you will do and back it with data. Avoid ‘word salad,’ where the reader still does not know what you will do, which he often sees from novice writers.

Q4: Common Pitfalls and How to Avoid Them (Nia)

- Many believe awards are pre-wired; it may or may not be, and people do business with people
- Being data-driven makes it hard for a favored competitor to out-score you
- Most common pitfall: opening with “Team X, Y and Z is great because we do this”; every proposal says that
- Corporation-heavy proposals speak to the company’s core strengths, not to the client’s and the competition’s positioning
- Past performance citations written by a technical SME or PM describing tasks not done on this contract waste valuable space
- Fix: a client-centric proposal

SPEAKER NOTES

Nia noted that many people believe everything is pre-wired. It may or may not be, because it is people doing business with people, including in government. But you can make it very difficult for a favored competitor to out-score you by being data-driven. The most common pitfall she sees in debriefs is a first sentence that says ‘team X, Y and Z is great because we do this.’ Every proposal says that, because no one will say their team is not great. Those proposals are corporation-heavy: they speak to the company’s own strengths, not to the client’s needs and the competition’s positioning. We see this in past performance citations written by a technical SME or program manager, describing tasks they do not even perform on this contract. That wastes expensive real estate where you could be collecting points. The fix is a client-centric proposal.

Q4 (continued): Kevin on Capture and Preparedness

- Proper capture and preparedness happen long before the RFP drops
- Strong proposal preparation can be hamstrung by weak capture, such as no relationships with government decision makers before the acquisition stage
- Compliance gaps surface late: approved accounting system, business system, ISO certification
- Some things can’t be manufactured once the RFP drops

SPEAKER NOTES

Kevin’s final thought was that proper capture and preparedness are critical, and that they happen well before the RFP drops. He has seen companies with great proposal preparation hamstrung because they did not do proper capture. Perhaps they had no chance to build relationships with government decision makers before the acquisition stage. Or they discovered compliance requirements they now had to scramble to satisfy, such as an approved accounting system, a business system or an ISO certification. Some things you simply cannot manufacture once the RFP drops.

Key Takeaways

- “Outstanding” can still lose; “far exceeds” wins by beating both client expectations and the competition
- Data-packed proposals win; Shipley has seen it for 50+ years
- Even after the RFP drops, invest about 20% of your time in capture: client first, then competition
- Proposal teams need their own real-time market intelligence (GovWin, FPDS, SAM, USAspending)
- Design the benefit first and tie it to the client need and the competitor’s solution
- Replace adjectives with data; address competitor weaknesses without naming them
- Open client-centric, not “we’re great,” and prepare (relationships, compliance) well before the RFP

SPEAKER NOTES

Use this slide as your recap. If your audience remembers one thing, it should be that data is what converts an outstanding proposal into one that far exceeds. Walk through each point and link it back to the earlier sections. Presenter’s suggestion (not from the video): pause here for audience questions before moving to the glossary.

Glossary (1 of 4): Scoring and Process

Advanced proposal writing	Specific, data-driven techniques to move your score beyond “good” and from outstanding to far exceeds on competitive best-value bids.
Outstanding vs. far exceeds	Outstanding can still lose; far exceeds means far exceeding client expectations and the competition (green to blue in government scoring).
Best-value procurement	Competitive award with formal, documented scoring; cost is a main criterion but not the only one.
Down-select and debrief	Down-select: being narrowed to the top bidders (for example, the top three). Debrief: the client’s scoring feedback afterward.
Protest	A formal challenge in government contracting; one reason evaluators keep documented, delineated scoring.
Capture	Research and positioning work done before writing; the “science” of collecting and analyzing data about client and competitors.
P-win	The probability of winning; more preparation time raises it, and lack of agency knowledge lowers it.

SPEAKER NOTES

Use this glossary to define terms as they come up. Definitions reflect how the speakers used each term in the video; where the video did not define a term, the entry stays close to how it was used.

Glossary (2 of 4): Proposal Writing Concepts

Four C’s (Shipley)	Shipley’s focus order: client, customer, company, then cost last on best value [second “C” unclear in the transcript].
Discriminator	A content-driven differentiator that sets you apart, built from client and competitor research.
Feature and benefit	Feature: what you offer. Benefit: what it does for the client. Design the benefit first and tie it to the client need and competitor solution.
Win theme	A central message of the bid; tie it to the agency’s strategy.
Pink team (notional)	An early draft-level view when the RFP drops: management and technical volumes, price idea, key personnel and past performance.
Past performance / relevant experience	Evidence of similar size, scope and complexity; risk mitigation for the client (called relevant experience in business-to-business).
Word salad	Vague writing where the reader still can’t tell what you will do.
Client-centric proposal	Opens with the client’s needs, current state and goals rather than the company’s own strengths.

SPEAKER NOTES

Use this glossary to define terms as they come up. Definitions reflect how the speakers used each term in the video; where the video did not define a term, the entry stays close to how it was used.

Glossary (3 of 4): Market Intelligence and Data Sources

GovWin	Deltech’s market intelligence platform: opportunity tracking, agency and competitor intelligence, real-time alerts synced with SAM.
Integrated Acquisition Environment	Statutory set of programs, mostly operated by GSA, providing tools and data for acquisition professionals, customers and contractors.
FPDS	Federal Procurement Data System: the system of record for contract activity.
USAspending	A public representation of FPDS data.
SAM.gov	Source of procurement opportunities and required registration for companies and subcontractors.
Unique entity identifier	Registration identifier from SAM.gov that replaced the old DUNS number.
NAICS codes	Industry codes in a company’s SAM record; also used to search competitors’ contracts.
Firmographic data	Company facts such as location, headquarters, affiliations and socioeconomic status.

SPEAKER NOTES

Use this glossary to define terms as they come up. Definitions reflect how the speakers used each term in the video; where the video did not define a term, the entry stays close to how it was used.

Glossary (4 of 4): Contracting and Policy Terms

IDIQ (large-vehicle)	A large contract vehicle with thousands of competitors; not a best-value direct award, so compliance is key.
Incumbent / recompete	Incumbent: the current contractor. Recompete: renewed competition for existing work.
Debarment / suspension	Status barring the government from doing business with a company; verify no one on your team is excluded.
CMMC	Cybersecurity certification asked of defense contractors handling controlled unclassified data.
Mentor-protégé joint venture	A small and large business partnership used to strengthen past performance and bid.
Reduction in force (RIF)	Agency workforce reductions, which vary by agency and may mean contact turnover.
Transition, badge-flipping and staffing plans	Management-volume plans that reduce client risk; badge-flipping applies to classified work.

SPEAKER NOTES

Use this glossary to define terms as they come up. Definitions reflect how the speakers used each term in the video; where the video did not define a term, the entry stays close to how it was used.